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The journey of this book began in Berlin. There, from my first visit in 2004 to a summer graduate residency in 2008 and nearly annual trips forward, I was drawn in by the city and its residents to explore, reflect, engage, and write. Over time, I found significant material for consideration in archives, museums, galleries, and academic conferences. I was also led to some of my most inspired and grounded thoughts while walking or biking through the city; outside in streets, parks, and waterways; around the footprint of memorials and monuments; and following the path of the former Wall and its myriad unlikely intersections and points of perspectives. Along the way, I encountered stories of American visitors and expatriates and sought out artworks and texts in which they traced their Berlin projects. In turn, I was also led to narratives of German Jewish émigrés, transnational scholars and artists of color, immigrant and refugee communities, queer and feminist collectives, and many others who lived in the city, together, at one point or another. Berlin spoke to me as a space of haunt and of home, of existential angst and profound understanding, as it has for so many others seeking critical distance over the course of multiple generations. I found a city that beckons a sense of balance, even with its hard edges and the heaviest of burdens that dwell in its history and culture.

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